

Chronos — how the game works

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A guide to the game itself: what the player sees, how they win, how they lose, and what is built so far.

Written 2026-08-19 by reading the live game rules. No database or server talk — this is the game as a player meets it.

1. What Chronos is

Chronos is a **historical escape game**. You are dropped into a real moment in history with a few hours of in-game time, a handful of objectives, and a disaster on a timer.

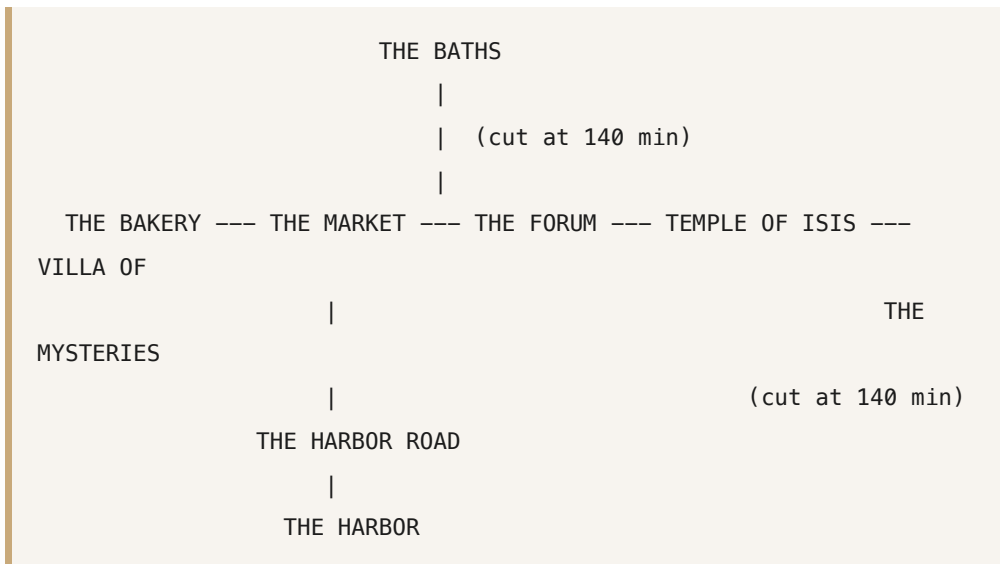
You do not fight anything. You **move around a city, collect what you need, talk to people, and get out before time runs out**. The tension comes entirely from the clock.

One scenario exists today: **Escape Pompeii**, year 79 AD.

Mount Vesuvius has begun to stir above Pompeii. You have a few hours to understand what is coming, earn the trust of the people who can help you, and reach a ship before the city is buried.

2. The city

Pompeii is **8 locations** joined by roads. You can only walk between places that are directly connected — there is no fast travel.



You start at **The Forum**. The only way out of Pompeii is **The Harbor**, four roads away.

Who is where

Person	Role	Where
Marcus	Merchant	The Forum
Livia	Priestess of Isis	Temple of Isis
Quintus	Baker	The Bakery
Lucius	Ship Captain	The Harbor

What is lying around

Item	Where	What it does
City Map	The Forum	Nothing when used — it is a quest item
Silver Denarius	The Market	Nothing when used
Loaf of Bread	The Bakery	Restores 15 health , then is eaten
Water Flask	The Baths	Restores 20 health , then is drunk
Oil Lamp	Villa of the Mysteries	Nothing when used
Ship Token	Villa of the Mysteries	Nothing when used — but Lucius will not take you without it

3. What you see on screen

The game screen has **six** parts.

ESCAPE POMPEII		Health 100/100 · Time 00:00 ·	
active ← 1. HUD			
2. LOCATION	3. THE SCENE	5. MISSION	
MAP	Where you are and	Your	
objectives	what it looks like		
Every place in			
the city, and			
whether you can	4. EVENT LOG	6. INVENTORY	
walk there now	What the mountain	What you	
carry,	has done so far	with a Use	
button			
		ITEMS HERE	
		What is on the floor,	
		with a Pick up button	

1. The HUD

Three numbers along the top, always visible.

- **Health** — out of 100, with a bar
- **Time** — shown as hours and minutes, starting at 00:00

- **Status** — active, completed, or failed

2. The location map — *your main tool*

This is the panel you plan with. It lists every location in the city and tells you, for each one, whether you can walk there **right now**.

Not to be confused with the City Map item. The panel is part of the interface and is there from the first move. The City Map lying at the Forum is a story prop that does nothing when used — it exists only to satisfy objective 2. Picking it up unlocks no features.

What it shows	What it means for you
You are here	Your current location, highlighted
Reachable	A road connects it and the road is open — click to go
Road destroyed	A road exists, but the eruption has cut it. Shown in red. Not clickable
Out of reach	No direct road from where you stand. Go somewhere else first
Unexplored	You have never set foot there. Dimmed, dashed border

How the map helps you. Three ways:

1. **It stops you wasting time.** Every move costs 10 minutes whether it was a good idea or not. The map tells you what is actually possible before you spend the clock.
2. **It warns you the city is closing.** When a road turns red, that route is gone for the rest of the game. If your plan depended on it, you need a new plan immediately.
3. **It shows you how much you have seen.** The header reads *"You are at The Forum — 2 of 8 explored"*, so you know how much of the city is still unknown.

3. The scene

The name and description of where you are standing. Underneath it, **Items here** — a short list of anything lying on the floor of this room, each with a **Pick up** button.

4. The event log

A running list of everything the mountain has done, newest first, each stamped with the minute it happened.

140 min Roofs across the city give way under the weight of the ash.

 The air is almost unbreathable.

100 min Stones of hot pumice rain down. Every moment in the open costs you.

60 min Fine grey ash begins to fall across Pompeii, settling on shoulders

 and roof tiles.

30 min The ground shudders. Cups rattle off a table somewhere behind you.

Before anything has happened it reads: *"The city is quiet — for now."*

What it is for. The event log is your record of how bad things have got. Events fire on a fixed timetable, so the log doubles as a warning: once you have seen the 100-minute pumice storm, you know the roof collapse is 40 minutes away and the end is 80 minutes away.

5. Mission

Your objectives, in order, each marked **Locked**, **In progress**, **Completed** or **Failed**.

6. Inventory

What you are carrying, with a quantity and a **Use** button on each item.

4. What you can do

Three actions. **Every one of them costs time.**

Action	Time cost	What it does
Move to a connected location	10 minutes	Walk somewhere new
Pick up an item lying here	5 minutes	Add it to your inventory
Use an item you carry	5 minutes	Trigger its effect; consumables are used up
<i>(Wait — exists, but has no button)</i>	<i>as many minutes as asked</i>	<i>Let time pass on purpose</i>

The clock only moves when you act — so standing still is free, but achieves nothing.

There is a fourth action, **Wait**, which burns any number of minutes on purpose. It works, but **no button anywhere sets it off**, so no player can currently reach it. Worth knowing it exists: it would be the natural way to let someone deliberately let time pass, and it is one small control away from being usable.

This is the core tension of the game: *every single thing you do brings the eruption closer.*

5. The clock — Pompeii's timetable

Five events fire at fixed minutes. They are the same every game.

Minute	Event	What it does to you
30	First tremor	Warning only
60	Ashfall begins	Warning only
100	Pumice storm	–15 health
140	Roof collapse	–25 health , and cuts two roads : Forum↔Baths and Temple↔Villa
180	Final surge	Game over. You lose, whatever your health

180 minutes is your entire budget. At 10 minutes a move, that is **18 moves** total, and only if you pick nothing up.

The 140-minute roof collapse is the cruel one. It cuts the road to the **Villa** — and the Villa is where the Ship Token is. Arrive late and the item you need to board the ship becomes unreachable, but the game does not end. You walk to the harbour and are turned away.

6. Health

You start at **100** and cannot go above it.

What takes it away: only events. The pumice storm at 100 minutes (–15) and the roof collapse at 140 (–25). Nothing else in the game hurts you.

What gives it back: eating. Bread restores 15, the water flask restores 20. Both are used up.

Health reaching 0 ends the game. But note the arithmetic: the two damaging events total 40 damage. **You cannot die of damage alone in a normal run** —

you would have to be extraordinarily slow. In practice health is a comfort, not a threat. The clock is the real enemy.

7. Objectives — how you make progress

Escape Pompeii has **five objectives, in a fixed chain**.

#	Objective	What completes it
1	Find Marcus	Talk to Marcus at the Forum
2	Get a City Map	Pick up the City Map
3	Consult the Priestess	Talk to Livia at the Temple
4	Find the Ship Token	Pick up the Ship Token at the Villa
5	Reach the Harbor	Move to the Harbor

They unlock one at a time. Only objective 1 starts active; the rest are **Locked**. Completing the active one unlocks the next.

This matters more than it sounds. **You cannot complete them out of order.** Standing in the Villa holding the Ship Token does nothing if objective 4 has not unlocked yet. The chain, not your inventory, decides your progress.

An objective can also **fail**, and a failed objective never recovers. When you lose, everything still locked or in progress is marked failed at once.

8. How you win

Complete all five objectives. That is the only win condition — every objective completed, in order.

You then get the **Victory screen**: "*You escaped Escape Pompeii*", with your final score, your remaining health, and your elapsed time.

9. How you lose

Two ways, and either is enough:

1. **Health reaches 0.**
2. **The 180-minute final surge fires.** This ends the game regardless of health, and regardless of how many objectives you had finished.

You get the **Game Over screen**: "*Pompeii was lost*", with your score, how many objectives you managed, and how long you survived.

There is no partial win. Four objectives out of five at minute 179 is a loss.

10. Score

Points are awarded like this:

For	Points
Each completed objective	100
Each location explored beyond your starting one	10
Only if you win: each point of remaining health	2
Only if you win: each minute left before the final surge	1

A losing run still scores — objectives and exploration always count. But the two big bonuses are locked behind winning, which makes the gap between a win and a near-miss very wide.

A perfect run is worth roughly:

5 objectives × 100	= 500
7 locations explored × 10	= 70
100 health × 2	= 200
~100 minutes left × 1	= 100
	———
	~870

The scoring rewards two things that pull against each other: **exploring** (10 a room) and **finishing fast** (1 a minute). Since a move costs 10 minutes and a new room is worth 10 points, wandering is almost exactly break-even — a nicely balanced accident.

11. What a good run looks like

The fastest sensible route, assuming talking is instant:

Forum	pick up City Map	5 min	(objective 2)
Forum	talk to Marcus		(objective 1)
→ Temple	move	10 min	
Temple	talk to Livia		(objective 3)
→ Villa	move	10 min	
Villa	pick up Ship Token	5 min	(objective 4)
→ Temple	move	10 min	
→ Forum	move	10 min	
→ Market	move	10 min	
→ Harbor Road	move	10 min	
→ Harbor	move	10 min	(objective 5 – WIN)
		80 min	

80 minutes, comfortably inside the 180 limit, finishing before the pumice storm at 100 even fires. You would take no damage at all.

That is the shape of the game: **not tight, if you know where you are going.** The difficulty is entirely in *not* knowing — wandering into the Bakery and the Baths, going the wrong way down the harbour road, and discovering the Villa is your goal only after the road to it has collapsed.

12. Where the build stands today

Feature	State
City, characters, items, objectives, events	Done
Moving between locations	Done
Picking up and using items	Done
Location map with blocked roads and explored places	Done
Inventory panel with item cards and quantities	Done
Mission panel with objective statuses	Done
Event log	Done
Health, the clock, timed events, blocked roads	Done
Win and lose conditions, scoring	Done
Victory and Game Over screens	Done
Register, log in, saved games	Done
Talking to characters	Not built
Pictures for locations and items	Not built
A second scenario	Not built
Admin tools for creating scenarios	Not built

13. The one thing that stops the game working

As of today, Escape Pompeii cannot be won.

Here is the chain:

1. Objectives unlock strictly in order.
2. Objective **1** is "**Find Marcus**", which is a *talk to a character* objective.
3. **Talking to characters is not built.** The game accepts three actions — move, pick up, use — and none of them can complete a talking objective.
4. So objective 1 can never complete, so objective 2 never unlocks, and neither does anything after it.

The practical result: you can walk around Pompeii, collect every item, watch the volcano erupt on schedule and die at minute 180 — but the Mission panel will read **1 of 5, in progress** the entire time, forever. Every game ends in a loss.

Everything else is finished and correct. **This single missing feature is what stands between the project and a playable game**, and it is the NPC dialogue

work, which is Person A's.

Two smaller notes while we are here:

- **Objectives 1 and 3 are both talking objectives, and they sit at positions 1 and 3 in the chain.** So dialogue is not optional polish — it is load-bearing in the middle of the critical path.
 - Because health can only drop by 40 across an entire game, **health is currently decorative.** Bread and the water flask restore more than the game can ever take away. Worth knowing before anyone spends time balancing them.
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14. What should happen next

In priority order:

1. **Build NPC dialogue** (*Person A*) — the single blocker. Until a player can talk to Marcus, nobody can finish the game, and it cannot be demonstrated end to end.
2. **Play one full game by hand once dialogue exists.** Every rule in this document has been read from the game's own logic, but **no one has ever completed a run.** The 80-minute route above is calculated, not played.
3. **Pictures** (*Person B*) — locations and items are text only. This is the last of Sprint 2.
4. **A second scenario** (*Person A*) and **admin tools** (*Person B*) — Sprint 3.

Worth considering, not on anyone's board:

- **Health does nothing.** Either make events hurt more, or make health matter some other way, or accept it as a comfort stat and stop investing in it.
- **The chain is unforgiving.** Collecting the Ship Token before objective 4 unlocks counts for nothing, and the game never tells you that. A player who explores well can be punished for it.
- **Nothing warns you the Villa road is about to close.** The 140-minute collapse can quietly make the game unwinnable while you are standing somewhere else, and you will not find out until you reach the harbour. A hint before the deadline would be kind.